of Bijapur. Ali Adil Shah II had recently brought back Shiism to his state, turning away from what had become an intolerant Sunni Islamic rule* and now promoted a simpler, more mystical kingship. He ‘dressed plainly… forbade the slaughter of animals at his court…held religious discussions with Hindus, and Muslims as well as Jesuits’.

Refugees from the increasingly repressive regime in Persia also began arriving at the Mughal court. One family in particular arrived in 1578 with not a great deal besides their personal talent and ambition. Ghiyas Beg was, at the time, just another nobleman fallen on hard times but he brought with him his daughter, the baby Mehr un-Nisa, who would have a remarkable destiny. She would become the most famous woman of the Mughal Empire —Noor Jahan. Another party that returned in the course of the year was an embassy that had been sent to Goa with strict instructions to bring back any European curiosities and crafts that might be of interest to Akbar. This resulted in a cacophonous procession returning to Fatehpur Sikri because the objects deemed curious included some European individuals, some Indians dressed in European clothes and playing the drums and the clarion, a man carrying an organ ‘like a great box the size of a man, played by a European sitting inside’, and other assorted items of interest.

Another most unorthodox event occurred when Akbar, while hunting in the vicinity of Palam outside Delhi, decided to spend the night in the house of the headman of the village, one Bhura. Bartoli, the Italian writer and historiographer, had noted that Akbar was ‘great with the great: lowly with the lowly’. With his boundless curiosity about human nature, Akbar would maintain till the end of his life a charismatic ability to communicate with all kinds of people, and he would take every opportunity to live alongside them, for a fleeting instance, or for a lifetime, as when he quarried stone, painted pictures, graded his matchlocks, slept in huts, and talked to his animal-keepers.

Akbar and the court too were in a state of flux as the Padshah had just moved the imperial camp to the Punjab. Here, in special consultation with Raja Todar Mal and Khwaja Shah Mansur, Akbar made a number of important decisions, one of which concerned the royal mint. Until then, the various mints had been in the charge of minor officials called chaudhuris. Now overall control would be delegated to a responsible ‘Master of the Mint’ and Akbar chose Abd al-Samad, the painter from Shiraz who had given him his childhood lessons in painting, as the first official to hold this